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IN RETREAT: The ice cap line in Kangerlussuaq has receded rapidly



factory. It produced the iceberg that possibly sank the *Titanic* in 1912. As we walk on the airport tarmac that overlooks Disko bay, Hedegaard tells me, "I have never seen so many icebergs build up at the fjord. It is causing a major traffic jam." We take a boat to see the icebergs, tinted a swimming pool blue, up close. A section of an iceberg collapses with a crack like a rifle shot, followed by what sounds like the thunder of artillery gunfire as more parts of it drop into the sea.

It's a war of a different kind and the ice-sheet is facing a losing battle. Between 1993 and 2003, Illulissat's Sermeq Kujalleq glacier doubled its speed to touch 12.6 km per year. In 2002, the tongue of the glacier disinte-

EXPERTS SAY WHAT IS NEEDED IS NOT BAND-AID BUT A TECTONIC SHIFT IN OUR APPROACH TO SOLUTIONS—CHANGING OUR LEADERS INSTEAD OF OUR BULBS.

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“How small you feel in front of the vast ice sheet and yet it is our footprint that is upsetting nature's delicate balance.”

CONNIE HEDEGAARD *Denmark's Minister for Climate and Energy*

also in the front seat, quips, "Maybe we should change our leaders, not our light bulbs."

Next morning we are up at 4 a.m. to catch the LC-130 flight to the NEEM project. With the weather being so unpredictable it's what Steffensen

calls the, "Hurry up and wait" approach. Which is what happens and we leave an hour later than scheduled. Inside, we are strapped up on foldable seats and prepare for the three-hour journey. Cargo meant for the site is strapped at the tail end of the aircraft that has a giant hatch to slide it out when the plane lands. The view from the portholes is awesome. The melting glaciers can be seen pushing down giant icebergs into the sea. From above they look like tiny ships anchored at the harbour. The aircraft touches down on the ski-way with a thump. Outside, the temperature is minus 9 degree Celsius—warm for Greenland at this time of the year.

We spend 24 hours at the camp (there is no day or night) and next morning wake up in time to watch the near total solar eclipse. We return to Kangerlussuaq and a day later take a commercial flight to Illulissat known as the iceberg

grated and retreated by as much as 12 km. A helicopter flies us over the glacier and lands at a point with a dramatic overview of its new front. Ice has piled up almost a km high and Hedegaard says, "How small you feel when you fly over the ice sheet and yet it is our footprint that is upsetting nature's balance."

Next day, over breakfast of Danish pastries at the Arctic Hotel, that overlooks the bay of icebergs, I ask Hedegaard what would happen if the NEEM study comes up with no new answers about global warming. Should the alarm be turned off then? She says calmly: "Science still doesn't have many of the answers. But as politicians we have to guide people and tell them that we see no rational reason why we shouldn't act. After all we are trying to switch to renewable sources of energy. The world has everything to gain from it and nothing to lose." That made sense. ■